Galatians

Rescued by grace · Learning to receive · Session 1

THE LETTER AT A GLANCE

Paul writes to churches in Galatia facing a question that reaches into our lives: Is Christ's saving work sufficient, or must we add something to be accepted by God? The letter addresses Gentile inclusion, circumcision, God's promise, and life in the Spirit. God's law and Jewish identity are not the enemy; Paul challenges added requirements as the basis of righteousness before God.

Chapters 1–2: the gospel received and defended. Chapters 3–4: faith, promise, law, and inheritance. Chapters 5–6: freedom, the Spirit, and faithful life together.

READ TOGETHER — GALATIANS 1:1–9 CSB

1 Paul, an apostle—not from men or by man, but by Jesus Christ and God the Father who raised him from the
dead— 2 and all the brothers who are with me: To the churches of Galatia.

3 Grace to you and peace from God the Father and our Lord Jesus Christ, 4 who gave himself for our sins to
rescue us from this present evil age, according to the will of our God and Father. 5 To him be the glory forever
and ever. Amen.

6 I am amazed that you are so quickly turning away from him who called you by the grace of Christ and are
turning to a different gospel— 7 not that there is another gospel, but there are some who are troubling you and
want to distort the gospel of Christ.

8 But even if we or an angel from heaven should preach to you a gospel contrary to what we have preached to
you, a curse be on him! 9 As we have said before, I now say again: If anyone is preaching to you a gospel
contrary to what you received, a curse be on him!

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Grace Begins with Jesus

Part 1 · Galatians 1:1–5

RECEIVE HIS RESCUE

Paul begins with God's action. His apostleship comes from Jesus Christ and the Father who raised Jesus from the dead. Grace and peace come from this same God. The gospel is the apostolic witness to the crucified and risen Jesus, rather than a program for making ourselves admirable enough to be accepted.

Jesus gives himself for our sins to rescue us. A person needing rescue cannot remove the danger by building a better record. Christ acts on our behalf and bears what we could not resolve for ourselves. Rescue takes place according to the Father's will, and God receives the glory. Through faith in Christ, we receive what we cannot earn.

Responsible work, care for others, and spiritual disciplines are good. But when they become the case we present for God's acceptance, each failure threatens our standing and each success invites comparison. Christ's work supplies the confidence our record cannot sustain. From received grace, we can repent, learn, keep commitments, and serve.

Let this gospel make room for honest brotherhood. Some of us find it easier to offer help than to receive it, or to sound certain than to admit a question. Because our hope rests in Christ, we can acknowledge need and receive prayer or help without making self-sufficiency the measure of our worth.

DISCUSS

1. How would you explain the gospel to someone who asked what you believe? Where does Jesus' action in 1:1–5 appear in your explanation?
2. How does Jesus' rescue encourage you, and what makes receiving help or admitting need difficult for you? What might one small step of trust look like?

NOTES AND REFLECTION

Guarding the Gospel

Part 2 · Galatians 1:6–9

KEEP CHRIST AT THE CENTER

Paul is alarmed that the churches are turning from the God who calls them in grace. A distorted message is not another legitimate gospel. As the letter unfolds, he confronts requirements such as circumcision being imposed on Gentile believers as necessary for righteousness before God. Adding a condition to Christ's work changes the foundation on which they stand.

The danger can appear in ordinary life. We may say Jesus saves while making our confidence depend on being dependable, having a spotless spiritual record, or never showing weakness. These responsibilities and habits cannot do the saving work that belongs to Christ. Grace gives us a place from which to obey, receive correction, and make wrongs right.

The gospel judges every messenger, even Paul himself. Credentials, sincerity, and confidence cannot make a contrary gospel true. Ask what a teaching says Christ has done, what it makes the basis of our confidence, and what it requires us to add. Test its claims against Scripture.

The warning in verses 8–9 is serious and belongs to God's judgment. It calls us to protect gospel truth and care for those affected by distortion. We can listen patiently and examine a claim together. Honest questions can lead to deeper understanding; a leader also remains open to correction.

DISCUSS

1. Where could an extra requirement become the basis of your confidence before God—for example, always being dependable, appearing spiritually strong, or having a record you can be proud of? What does 1:3–5 put at the center instead?

2. What would taking gospel truth seriously look like this week, and how could we encourage one another to depend on Christ rather than perform spiritual strength?

PRACTICE THIS WEEK

Reread Galatians 1:1–9. When you find yourself presenting your record as the reason God should accept you, return to Christ's action. Ask a trusted brother for prayer or help with one faithful next step. This response grows from grace; it does not earn acceptance.

PRAY

Father, thank you for your grace through Jesus. We bring you our pride, our failures, and our attempts to make ourselves secure. Teach us to receive Christ's rescue and to speak truth with love. By your Spirit, help us receive help and encourage others faithfully. Keep our confidence in Jesus. Amen.